The way to win a Moon Princess' heart

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The way to win a Moon Princess' heart

by Bagge

Summary

Micah attempts to woo Angella with a cunning scheme.

"Hupp, hupp, hupp!" Micah said.

"Hupp, hupp, hupp!" the gaggle of children that followed him happily repeated.

"Hupp, hupp, hupp!"

"Are you sure about this?" Netossa followed Micah and the children with a sceptical look.

Casta defensively crossed her arms. "It's his best bet to impress the princess."

"With a bunch of snotgoblins?"

"With a bunch of *children*, Netossa. Micah is good with children."

"I suppose it helps if you think like them."

"By hosting this outreach event, Mystacor shows goodwill and interest in the next generation of potential magic users. The princess has been invited to give her royal blessing or whatever elemental princesses are supposed to do, and Micah gets to show off his caring, nurturing and generous side."

"Yeah, yeah, I get it. The princess sees that he can deal with the little brats, and decides to boink him on the spot."

"Perhaps a little ambitious, but if he doesn't mess up, he will at least show that he's qualified for the position."

Netossa raised an eyebrow. "Your entire plan hinges on Micah not messing up?"

"I never said it was a perfect plan. Listen, all he has to do is fool around with a bunch of kids. How bad could it be?"

As on cue, a drawn out explosion was heard and black smoke billowed past the window. Micah's shouting voice could be heard: "I MEANT TO DO THAT."

Casta closed her eyes and massaged her temples.

Netossa gave a serious nod. "Never mind, I get it."

Spinnerella walked up to them, arms full of decorations. "Where is Micah?"

"Follow the smoke," Netossa said.

"You know what, never mind. We need to get these decorations up before the princess comes."

"And we need to make sure Micah gets all the kids back here in one piece."

"AND they need to finish their drawings of how much they love the princess."

Spinnerella gave the 'arts and crafts' station a dubious look. "Are you sure that's not too much?"

Casta scoffed. "For a normal person, sure. The princess *lives* for suckups like that."

"I feel you might do her a disservice..." Spinnerella gently said.

"She's still mad Micah worked up the courage to ask her out first," Netossa helpfully said. "Whaaaat? It's true."

"IS NOT!" Casta protested. "And even if it were, it doesn't matter how much he asks if she doesn't take him up on it."

"Which is why we need to get the decorations up, so he'll make a good impression. Now help me."

It took some more bickering, but soon Casta, Spinnerella and Netossa had decorated the room in Mystacor crystals and Brightmoon purple in a not-very-subtle hint. A long table was laid for the planned dinner, with two large chairs by the end for Micah and Angella.

"What about us?" Netossa complained.

"What about us?" Spinnerella asked.

"We can't be here," Casta explained. "If we are, the princess will want to spend all her time with us, and Micah will never have the chance to ask her out."

"Wouldn't that be a shame," Netossa grinned at Casta.

Spinnerella gave them a firm look. "This is Micah's big chance. We have to be supportive."

Netossa and Casta grudgingly nodded, as Micah and the children marched back, dripping of happiness - and also of mud.

"Hupp, hupp, hupp!"

"Hupp, hupp, hupp!"

"SUPPORTIVE!" Spinnerella cried as Casta descended on Micah with clenched fists.

"Out! Out! Out! No mud on the floor."

"We caught a frog!" One of the children reported and held up the aforementioned specimen for examination. It looked rather confused about the whole affair.

"No frogs on the floor!" Casta shooed frogs, children and brothers out through the door.

"What were you thinking?" she demanded, hands on hips.

"The kids wanted a frog."

"We wanted a frog," one of the kids happily confirmed.

"And you thought catching a frog for them would somehow be a good idea?"

"I thought that catching a frog for them would somehow be a good idea!"

Casta took a deep breath and slowly breathed out, in the manner Micah had come to recognise as the sister early warning system.

"Don't worry sis, I got this!" Micah waved his hands and a whirlwind of water surrounded the laughing and shrieking group, quickly cleaning away most of the mud. Casta glared at him, but did take another breath, which Micah took as encouragement.

"MY FROG!" One of the kids ran after the frog that had taken off in fright the moment the cleaning spell started.

"CATCH THE FROG!" Micah yelled in excitement, and was met with a general cheer from the kids.

Casta gave him a stage two sisterly warning glare. "Micah..."

"DON'T CATCH THE FROG!" Micah corrected, and was met with a much less enthusiastic response. "LEAVE THE FROG UNCAUGHT. Because.... we should keep focus on the business at hands, which is getting ready for the princess. You all want to look at your best self, right? And what does that entail? Yes?"

One of the little mushroom children raised his hand. "We want the princess to see that we are re-spon-si-ble young magicians that use magic re-spon-si-bly."

"Very good. What else?"

"We want to show the princess that we can conduct ourselves with decorum." This came from a slightly older child who recently had learnt the word 'decorum' and was dead set on getting use for it.

"Correctly. We are very big on decorum in Mystacor. Aren't we, Casta?"

"Some more than others, I'd say."

"There you go. And what else do we want the princess to see when she gets here? Yes"

"A frog?" This comment was met with a general cheer. Micah sadly shook his head.

"No, I fear my sister is right. The princess is far too dignified for frogs. When the princess gets here, she will see next generation of master magicians. She will see skill and power and creativity the like will make us old farts - no giggling - in Mystacor look like we do card tricks in comparisons. Right hand up!"

Obediently, the children held out their right hands palm up.

"Channel magic."

The children grunted and grimaced as they did their best to form the mental connection between their minds and the magic of Etheria (Casta knew that Micah was cheating slightly, saturating the area with easily accessible magic, but she was still impressed how many of them managed to form the link).

"Draw circle."

With more or less elegance, the children moved their hands in the general shape of a circle, forming glowing lines in the air.

"Aaaaaaand, as slowly as you can, RELEASE!"

Balls of light rose from the hands of the children. Some bobbed upwards like bubbles, popping after a few seconds. Some shot away like rubber balls. One overly enthusiastic little child of undetermined gender expression shot a beam of light right into the sky. But a few of the more experienced children created the floating, twinkling miniature stars Micah had spent the morning teaching them.

"That's actually really impressive," Casta grudgingly said.

"They are good kids."

"No, I meant *you* are really impressive to teach them that."

Micah opened his eyes wide in surprise that was only half feigned. "Praise, from you Casta?"

"Don't get used to it," she muttered. Then her expression became sincere. She stepped up to her brother and straightened his cravat. "You are impressive, Micah. For all that I'm giving you shit... you really have talent for magic. Light Spinner might have been an evil bitch, but she got that one right. And more importantly, you have a good heart, a generous personality and a mind that's occasionally capable of putting rational thought together - even if you for reasons I can't understand never seem to want to. What I'm trying to say is..." she sighed "...Princess Angella would be a fool to turn you down. You're a catch, bro, and you deserve the best."

Micah gave her a wet-eyed smile. "Wow, sis. Thank you. If you believe in me, I might even pull this off."

"Just don't get to cocksure," she warned him. "Just because you're good enough for the princess doesn't mean she'll see it that way. You still have to impress her."

"But even if my attempts to woo her fail in a humorous fashion, she'll see my real intent shining through and fall for my goofy charm and honest bravery, right?" Micah hopefully said. Casta bit her lips.

"Let's call that Plan B."

"Oh, OK. And what is Plan A?"

"Don't fuck up, bro."

"Thank you, that's really helpful."

"Read her poetry," one of the kids suggested. "Compare her to the moons."

"She knows that already. That's her job," another kid protested. "Make her laugh. Tell a joke."

"Laaaaame," said a third kid. "What you want to do is to show that you're father material. Show her how good you are with kids."

Micah nodded eagerly. "All right, and how do I do that?"

"Give us cookies?" the kid suggested.

Micah frowned. "And just how will that show the princess that I'm father material?"

"It will stop us from telling her you're bad with kids."

"This one has potential," Micah said as an aside to Casta. He turned to the kid again. "One cookie now, another during dinner, and you all better look extra adorable."

"You got yourself a deal, mister," the kid grinned. "You and the princess will be pollinating in no time."

"That's not quite what we mean with 'the birds and the bees', but you know what, I'll take it." He turned to Casta. "How do I look."

She gave him a critical look. His hair and beard was brushed, his nails were clean. He was dressed in a black jacket with silver lining, making him look dignified and cool, which even Casta had to admit. "As good as it'll get, unless you don't wise up in the last minute and let me remove that hideous beard."

He firmly shook his head. "The beard stays. The princess will see my inner light shine through."

"It might shine easier if the beard is not in the way."

"Stop yapping!" Netossa yelled at them. "We're finished with the hall. Come in and do your thing."

Micah took a deep breath and gave the children a serious look. "All right. It's showtime. Come on, everybody. Let's do some magic."

The kids excitedly rushed into the hall. Netossa and Spinnerella joined Casta. They all took turn giving Micah a hug.

"You can do this."

"Be your best self, but don't overdo it."

"No pollinating on the first date."

Spinnerella nodded at the others. "All right, let's get sparse. It's time for our little baby chick to try his wings."

"I'm not that short!" Micah yelled at them. Then he took a deep breath and turned towards the hall. "I've got this."

- - -

Everything was prepared. The table was set, the decorations in order. Several glowing spheres bobbed by the ceiling, emitting tasteful background music. The mushroom children milled around, chatting excitedly.

Micah clapped his hands. "All right everybody. Let's go through the program again. When the princess comes we will..."

"Sing the song of the moons," the children said in unison.

"Perfect, and after that?"

"We summon the sparks."

"Great. And then?"

"Then we show her the drawings."

"*And* be extra adorable while you do it. Now, we have to... yes?"

"I'm not done with my drawing."

"Me neither," another child said.

"Right... so, what we're doing first is FINISH THE DRAWINGS!" Micah dramatically pointed at the side table, where half of the children descended on papers and crayons like a flock of ravenous crows. The rest expectantly looked at Micah. "What are we doing?"

"You'll practice the song." Micah steered them to the opposite corner of the hall. "You all remember the lyrics, right!"

"Like, half of the words are 'moon', 'rays' or 'light'. We remember."

"Excellent! Yes, what can I help you with?"

The mushroom kid that had bartered for cookies grinned at him. "I trust you haven't forgotten about our deal."

"Of course not. In fact, you can hand out the cookies. Everyone gets one cookie, but no more until after we have eaten, you hear me?"

"Right you are, mister." He quickly grabbed the tray and walked over to the drawing table. Micah followed him and looked in appreciation at the emerging artwork.

"Wow! This is a really good drawing of the princess. Wait, is that supposed to be me?"

"You hoped to smooch her, right?" the artist said with bright voice.

"I might harbour some hopes in that general direction," Micah admitted. "Even so, perhaps wait with showing her this drawing until she has come to that conclusion herself."

"Um... Mister!" Micah turned around to see who had spoken, and blinked as he saw several mushroom children float in the air.

"You.... are not supposed to do that," he managed, really not knowing what else to say.

"Geee, thank you mister. We couldn't have figured that out on our own."

"Why are you floating? *How* are you floating?"

One of the kids, a small girl with yellow mushroom cap, rolled her eyes. "Well, I'm not a Mystacor Master Magician, but I kinda guess.... by magic?"

"Have children always been this sarcastic?" Micah wondered out loud as he made a series of complicated magical circles in the air. "Aha! Just as I thought. It's magic!"

"Gee, mister. What would we do without you?"

"I'm afraid the answer to that is that you wouldn't be floating," Micah admitted. "It seems like the magic I channelled for you interacted with the song and made you lighter. Perhaps there were too many 'moonlight' in the lyrics. Don't worry. I can counteract the effect by switching the upness and downess so you... oooops."

As Micah finished his spell, the floating children returned to the ground, but at the same time the drawing children floated up into the air.

"Was that supposed to happen?"

"Um.... not quite. But I can see how shifting upness and downess would result in excess of upness if you only have downess to begin with." Micah quickly drew a new set of symbols in the air, which made all of the children hover just above the air.

"There we go. Good enough for now. Just try to avoid sudden movements."

"I FOUND THE FROG!" A child rushed in from outside the hall and bumped straight into one of the floating children, which shot away and bumped into the next. This set off a chain reaction where one child bumped into the next, which bumped into the next and so on. Since they hovered over the ground they were practically frictionless, and before Micah knew it, the hall was full of kid-shaped projectiles."

"AAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHH!" In full panic, Micah filled the room with magic foam. He collapsed the tables. The decorations tore down from the walls. The frog took off in fright. But Micah managed to cushion all the children before they crashed into the walls.

"My frog!" the hapless child cried and chased after it.

"Everyone OK?" Micah anxiously asked, and got generally affirming grunts for an answer. He breathed out and looked around at the chaos.

"OK, so that one was on me. Sorry about the table and decorations."

"The princess..."

"Yes, I know. She can be here at any moment."

"No, I mean..."

"And when she gets here, everything has to be perfect."

"No, I mean she's already here."

Micah froze and slowly turned around. Princess Angella stood in the doorway, dressed in a long, white dress, watching the scene in amused silence.

"There's the princess," the child helpfully pointed out.

"Here's indeed the princess," Angella confirmed.

"She has been there for a few minutes," another child said.

"So I have."

"Um...." Micah said, feeling that perhaps he should contribute. "I, um, can explain."

"Can you?" Angella said with a raised eyebrow. "Because if so, I *really* look forward to hear it."

"Things... got out of hand."

"I dare say they did," Angella answered, voice clearly amused. She let her gaze sweep over the ruined table, destroyed decorations and foamy, happy children. Her gaze stopped on one of the older kids.

"Hello little one," she said with friendly voice. She took a step closer and hunched down to get in eye level with the suddenly shy child. "Can I ask for your advice on an important issue?"

"Of course, your majesty," the child mumbled, not quite daring to meet the eyes of the radiant princess.

"I'm much obliged," the princess said with a light little laughter that helped put the child at ease. "I much value your judgement in this matter, you see."

"Oh, um, yeah, what is it?" the child asked, uncertain of where the princess was going.

"What's your opinions on this man?" Angella nodded to Micah, making clear that he was to be spoken about but not to be part of the conversation.

"Oh, he's... all right?" the kid said, slightly uncertain.

"'All right' I see," Angella said thoughtfully. "I have been told that he can be considered 'funny'. Would you agree?"

"Oh, yeah, super funny," the child said, more confident.

"Super funny?" Angella repeated. "That's high praise."

"Oh, he is," the child assured her. "I loved that flying spell."

"I didn't do it on purpose," Micah protested.

Angella considered this.

"I have also heard that he can be brave. Would you agree?"

"He didn't try to hide or blame someone else when the table collapsed. I do that, sometimes," the child admitted, slightly ashamed.

"To stand for ones action truly takes bravery." Angella gave the child a kind smile. "And to admit ones failings takes perhaps even more so. I can then conclude that you and Micah both are exceptionally brave."

She lowered her voice to a conspiratorial theatre whisper. "There are those that would consider him 'handsome'. Would you agree?"

"Um...."

"Because I might actually agree with them." Angella pointedly looked at Micah - who simply stood there, enduring the scrutiny in awkward silence.

"He looks OK, I guess."

"And are there any other factors I should take into account?"

"He... can catch frogs?" the child suggested. Angella thoughtfully nodded to herself.

"The thing is this." Angella shot Micah another teasing look, "that this sorcerer has offered to kiss me, and I have yet to decide whether I should take him up on the offer or not. Any perspective on my quandary would be much welcome."

The child frowned. "Do you want to kiss him?"

Angella gave the sheepish-looking sorcerer a warm smile. "You know, I think I might."

"Then I think you should," the child concluded.

"You give excellent advice." Angella gently touched the cheek of the child. She stood over and walked over to Micah, who stood as rooted to the spot.

"So. The sorcerer himself. The brave, handsome, funny man. What a catch for a poor princess like myself. What do you have to say for yourself?"

"I would like to say that I'm not normally like this."

"But...?" she prompted.

He shrugged. "But I don't like lying."

She clearly tried not to laugh. "So we're adding 'honest' to the list. A man of many virtues, it would seem."

"I... try?" He blinked as she put a soft hand on his cheek.

"You also have people who can vouch for you." She nodded at the child. "That counts for a lot in my book."

"Oh?" he hopefully answered.

"'Oh', indeed. Now," she went on with business-like voice, "I hear you can catch frogs."

"I... think I can do that, yes?"

"Excellent. Then I suggest that we help the children clean up the venue and go about the program. I very much want to hear their song, see their sparks and admire their drawings. And after that you and me will go down to the swamp for a date." Angella leaned closer, her warm lips just about touching his ears. "And

then, If you can grant me a good enough frog, I *might* let you kiss me."

Micah considered that.

"Crikey!"

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